

The Cordwell Eval Games

Fool the Metric. Judge the Model. Fix the Pipeline.

How the Game Works

You are a team of three engineers at Cordwell Home and Hardware, the retailer behind the store-associate assistant you have been seeing on the slides. Three rounds, thirty to forty-five minutes, points on the board. Your facilitator is the host and the judge of last resort.

Round 1: Fool the Metric

The slides claim that BLEU and ROUGE measure word overlap against a reference, not correctness. Prove it. Here is the gold reference answer for the customer question "What primer do I need under oil paint on pine?":

Reference: "Use CordSeal S-100 shellac primer on pine before oil paint."

Challenge A: The Con (1 point)

Write a model response that would score HIGH on word overlap with the reference, but that would be wrong, harmful, or expensive if a real Cordwell customer followed it. The sneakiest response in the room gets the point.

Our response: _____

Challenge B: The Injustice (1 point)

Write a model response that is completely correct and genuinely helpful to this customer but shares almost no words with the reference. Lowest overlap while staying fully right wins.

Our response: _____

Before the share-out, agree as a team: which of your two responses would ROUGE rank higher, and which one would a customer thank you for?

Round 2: You Be the Judge

String overlap is out. You are the evaluation now. Your assistant answered the primer question four different times. Score each response for faithfulness using the rubric below and the retrieved context the model was given.

Retrieved context (what the model saw)

Chunk 1: “CordSeal S-100 is a shellac-based primer stocked in Aisle 4. It is recommended under oil-based paint on bare pine.”

Chunk 2: “Apply CordSeal S-100 in thin coats. Recoat time is 45 minutes. Not rated for exterior use.”

The rubric (from the slides)

Score	Meaning
5	Every claim is directly supported by the source
4	All major claims supported; minor elaboration present
3	Most claims supported; one unsupported detail
2	Mixed support; meaningful unsupported content
1	Mostly unsupported or contradicts source

The four responses

Response A: “CordSeal S-100 in Aisle 4 is the right primer for bare pine under oil-based paint. Apply thin coats and wait 45 minutes to recoat.”

Response B: “Great question, and honestly you have come to exactly the right place for it. As any seasoned painter will tell you, priming bare pine correctly is the single most important step in the whole project, and the good news is that Cordwell has you completely covered. The primer you want is CordSeal S-100, which you will find stocked in Aisle 4, and it is the recommended choice under oil-based paint on bare pine. When you apply it, the professional approach is thin coats, and you will want to give it a full 45 minutes before recoating. A truly excellent choice for this project, and one you will not regret.”

Response C: “CordSeal S-100 in Aisle 4 is the right primer for bare pine under oil-based paint. Apply thin coats and wait 45 minutes to recoat. Shellac primers like this one are also great at sealing knots in pine so they will not bleed through your topcoat.”

Response D: “CordSeal S-100 in Aisle 4 is what you want under oil-based paint on pine. Cordwell Pro members also get a 40 percent contractor discount on all primers, and it works great on exterior trim as well.”

Phase 1: Silent scoring

No talking. Each team member scores all four responses alone, 1 to 5, and writes them in their own column below. Your team earns a point if your independent scores land closest together in the room, so resist the urge to peek.

Response	Judge 1	Judge 2	Judge 3	Team final
A				
B				
C				
D				

Phase 2: Reconcile

Compare scores. Where you disagree, argue it out and agree on one team score per response. Then answer:

- Where exactly was the rubric ambiguous? Which response exposed it?

- Write ONE sentence you would add to the rubric so three strangers would score more consistently than you just did. (1 point for the sharpest sentence in the room.)

Round 3: Triad Triage

You are now the on-call rotation for the Cordwell assistant. The dashboard shows the last hour's mean scores for the three legs of the RAG Triad, plus one sample transcript per incident. For each card, write three things: the diagnosis (which pipeline component broke), the first fix you would try, and the confirming signal (which score should move, and in which direction, if your fix worked). One point per card for a defensible diagnosis and fix. Diagnose before you prescribe.

Card 1: The Vanishing Aisle

Context Relevance	Groundedness	Answer Relevance
0.35	0.90	0.55

Sample transcript: Customer: "What deck stain holds up in full sun?" Retrieved chunks: three passages about copper pipe fittings. Assistant: a perfectly accurate summary of copper pipe fittings in Aisle 12.

Diagnosis: _____

First fix: _____

Confirming signal:

Card 2: The Generous Robot

Context Relevance	Groundedness	Answer Relevance
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0.92	0.30	0.85
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Sample transcript: Customer: “How much is CordSeal S-100?” Retrieved chunks: correct pricing and product passages for CordSeal S-100. Assistant: quotes the correct price, then adds that Cordwell Pro members get a 40 percent contractor discount and that this weekend is a double loyalty points event. Neither program exists.

Diagnosis: _____

First fix: _____

Confirming signal:

Card 3: The Enthusiastic Tangent

Context Relevance	Groundedness	Answer Relevance
0.88	0.92	0.40

Sample transcript: Customer: “Which caulk should I use around a bathtub?” Retrieved chunks: caulk types including tub-rated silicone. Assistant: an accurate, fully supported walk through the history and product lineup of every caulk Cordwell stocks. It never recommends one.

Diagnosis: _____

First fix: _____

Confirming signal:

Bonus Card: The Perfect Scores Problem (1 point)

Context Relevance	Groundedness	Answer Relevance
0.93	0.95	0.91

Sample transcript: Customer: “How do I change the blade on my circular saw?” Assistant: an accurate, grounded, on-topic answer written in dense contractor jargon, with no mention of unplugging the saw first. Complaint tickets about the assistant are rising anyway.

Every Triad leg is green and customers are still unhappy. What can the Triad not see here, and what NEW check would you add to catch it? Anything a rubric can express can become a metric.

What the Triad missed:

Our new check: _____